ARTIST COMMONS

ART & AUTHORSHIP · SESSION 3A

What Makes It Mine?

Art & Authorship:
Originality & Lineage

POST-SESSION TOOLKIT

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> This toolkit accompanies the Artist Commons session *What Makes It Mine? Art & Authorship, Session 3a: Originality & Lineage*. Use it as a reference, a springboard for studio reflection, and a guide for further exploration.

NAVIGATE THE TOOLKIT

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How to Use This Toolkit

This document presents four philosophical frameworks for thinking about how new work emerges from what came before. These are not competing truths to choose between. Think of them as diagnostic tools for your own practice. Each directs attention to a different relation among the artist, the work, its influences, and its history.

Kant asks what an artwork makes possible when no existing rule could fully prescribe it. Eliot places the new work inside an active historical field. Bloom follows the pressure of a powerful influence and looks for the point where the later work changes direction. Krauss shows that even our strongest claims to originality depend on forms, objects, and systems that can be repeated.

The goal is not to prove that the work came from nowhere. The goal is to develop better language for what the work inherits, what it changes, and what contribution becomes visible through those choices.

Overview
the framework's core claim

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the people discussed in Rebecca's talk

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tensions and productive limits

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Remember: These frameworks are tools. Use them when they're useful. Set them aside when they're not.

01 Genius and Exemplary Originality

Original art is not fully prescribed by an existing rule. An exemplary work opens a possibility other artists can learn from without giving them a recipe.

OVERVIEW

Immanuel Kant was an eighteenth-century Prussian philosopher. In the *Critique of the Power of Judgment*, published in 1790, he asks how fine art can be made if no rule or method can fully determine what the artist should do.

A rule-first practice begins with something already known: a perspective system, a glaze recipe, a printing method, a genre convention, or an established idea of what a successful work should look like. The artist applies that rule with skill. Kant's account of genius reverses the sequence. The work has to happen before its rule becomes visible.

This does not mean that the artist creates from nothing. The work still depends on materials, techniques, histories, habits, teachers, and earlier art. Kant's narrower claim is that those things do not add up to a formula that could have prescribed this particular work in advance.

Kant's account has two parts. **Originality** means that the work could not have been fully produced by following an existing rule. **Exemplarity** means that the work becomes a model for other artists. They can learn from the possibility it opens, but they cannot recover its originality by copying its appearance.

That distinction changes the studio question. Instead of asking whether nobody has ever done anything like this before, ask what becomes possible because this work exists. The answer can be modest. A work might make a new material relation possible inside your practice, give a community a different image of itself, or make one person notice something that had been difficult to see.

Senga Nengudi's *R.S.V.P.* series makes this concrete. Nengudi stretches, knots, suspends, fills, and activates nylon mesh in relation to sand, gravity, architecture, movement, and the body. The work's contribution is larger than the instruction "make sculpture from pantyhose." It opens a way to understand ordinary material as a system for weight, tension, vulnerability, elasticity, memory, and bodily relation.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Immanuel Kant (1724–1804)

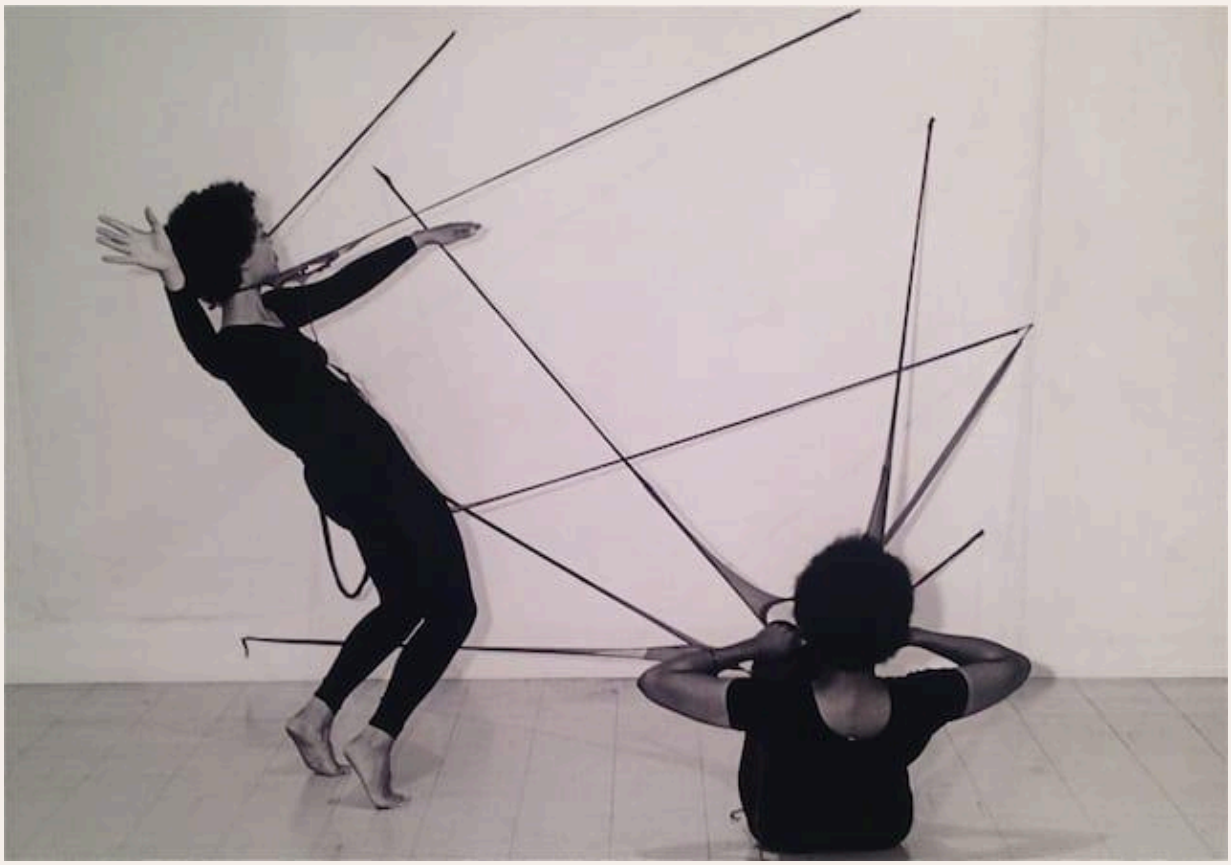
Kant describes genius as the capacity through which art receives a rule that could not have been stated in advance. Originality alone is not enough. The work must also be exemplary, capable of opening a path for other artists without becoming a recipe.

Linda Nochlin (1931–2017)

Nochlin's 1971 essay "Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?" redirects attention from the supposed absence of genius to the conditions that allow artists to develop, become visible, and endure. Training, time, money, studio space, patronage, institutions, networks, and expectations all shape who can appear as an originator.

Senga Nengudi (b. 1943)

Nengudi works across sculpture, installation, performance, and collaborative practice. Her *R.S.V.P.* works use the behavior of nylon, sand, gravity, and the body to make pressure and relation physically present. The work offers a model of originality that does not depend on scarcity or isolation.



Senga Nengudi, documentation of work from the *R.S.V.P.* series, begun 1975; nylon mesh and sand. Exact iteration, venue, performer, and photographer are not established by the supplied image.

Where It Gets Complicated

The history of genius has a recognition problem. Some artists are named as originators while other people and traditions are reduced to influence, source, craft, assistant, muse, intuition, or background. Nochlin helps us keep what is useful in Kant without turning the artist into a person outside history. A work can open a path and still depend on material access, training, cultural inheritance, collaborators, care, conversation, and institutional support.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 1.1 What Does This Work Make Possible? · 1.2 Rule First / Work First · 1.3 Change One Condition

Exercise 1.1: What Does This Work Make Possible?

Choose one finished or in-progress work. Set aside the question “Is it original enough?” for ten minutes.

1. Name one material, formal, spatial, social, or perceptual possibility the work makes available.
2. Describe what another artist might learn from that possibility without copying the work’s appearance.
3. Name the next decision that would make the possibility clearer.

The philosophical question: Exemplarity shifts attention away from proving the identity of the artist and toward what the work makes possible.

Try It in the Studio

Exercise 1.2: Rule First / Work First

Choose one process you know well. Make two quick studies using the same material and the same amount of time.

1. In Study A, follow one familiar rule, method, or habit.
2. In Study B, begin the same way, then let one resistance, accident, or emerging relation redirect a decision.
3. Place the studies side by side. Point to the decision that only became available through making.
4. Complete: Handling _____ changed my rule from _____ to _____.

The philosophical question: If handling the work changes the rule, making has done more than execute a plan.

Exercise 1.3: Change One Condition

Choose one work that has begun to open a path in your practice.

1. Name one condition that shaped what became possible: time, space, tools, money, training, permission, conversation, access, care, collaboration, a deadline, or a mistake.
2. Make one small test in which you deliberately alter that condition. Change the time limit, scale, tool, site, sequence, collaborator, or level of access.
3. Compare the test with the earlier work. What became possible, and what disappeared?
4. Choose one condition you now need to request, schedule, build, borrow, or protect.

The philosophical question: Conditions do not explain the work away. Changing one can reveal how artistic possibility is materially supported.

Go Further with the Framework

Accessible Reading List

- Hannah Ginsborg / Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. ***Kant's Aesthetics and Teleology***
  Guide to genius, originality, exemplarity, aesthetic ideas, and taste. · Free/open
- Immanuel Kant. ***The Critique of Judgement***
  Free full text; §§46–50 distinguish genius, imitation, rule-giving, and taste. · Free/open
- Douglas Burnham / Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy. ***Immanuel Kant: Aesthetics***
  Approachable context for fine art, purposiveness, judgment, and genius. · Free/open
- Linda Nochlin / ARTnews. ***Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?***
  Institutional correction: access, training, patronage, recognition, and power shape who can appear exemplary. · Free/open

Further Reading

- Immanuel Kant / Cambridge University Press. ***Critique of the Power of Judgment***
  Guyer–Matthews scholarly translation for close work on §§43–50. · Book / purchase or library
- Paul Guyer. ***Kant's Conception of Fine Art***
  How genius supplies rules while taste constrains and communicates what genius produces. · Article / JSTOR or library
- Lucy Delap. ***The Superwoman: Theories of Gender and Genius in Edwardian Britain***
  A historical account of how genius, exceptionality, and gender politics became entangled. · Open-access PDF
- Mignon Nixon. ***Women, Art, and Power After Linda Nochlin***
  A concise reflection on Nochlin's institutional critique and its continuing account of art, ideology, and power. · Free PDF

02 Tradition and the Historical Sense

The past helps us read the new work, and the new work changes how the past can be seen.

OVERVIEW

T. S. Eliot's 1919 essay "Tradition and the Individual Talent" begins with a different picture of originality. The artist does not stand alone at the origin of the work. They work inside inherited languages, forms, histories, and problems.

Eliot calls the artist's active relation to the past the **historical sense**. Tradition is not simply a list of admired predecessors or something an artist possesses by birth. It has to be studied and acquired. Earlier works form an active order, and the new work is understood in relation to that order.

The movement does not go in only one direction. The past helps us read the new work, but the new work also changes how the past is arranged. Once a work enters the tradition, different relations become visible. A history that looked settled can become incomplete, narrower, or newly connected.

Faith Ringgold's *Tar Beach* brings painting, quilting, written narrative, family memory, childhood imagination, and Black life in Harlem into one work. After the work enters the conversation, it becomes harder to keep painting, textiles, autobiography, storytelling, and Black feminist art in separate histories. The work does not merely take a place inside an existing tradition. It changes what that tradition has to include.

Firelei Báez works with this relation directly on historical pages. In *Man Without a Country*, 225 pages from late nineteenth-century books about Hispaniola are removed from their bound sequence and installed across a wall. Báez adds painted and drawn figures, maps, organisms, and ornamental forms. The inherited history remains visible, but it no longer controls the reading by itself.

The printed pages shape what we can see in Báez's interventions. Báez's marks also change how the pages can be read. The work makes tradition into a material relation: something the artist can separate, interrupt, combine, and rearrange.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

T. S. Eliot (1888–1965)

Eliot describes tradition as an active historical order rather than a dead inheritance. Individual talent appears in the transformation of inherited language and form. The new work belongs to a history, but it also changes how that history can be seen.

Faith Ringgold (1930–2024)

Ringgold brought painting, textiles, written story, autobiography, family history, and Black feminist experience together in works that changed what institutions and viewers could recognize as painting, narrative, and fine art.

Firelei Báez (b. 1981)

Báez works across painting, drawing, installation, folklore, maps, and colonial archives. She often paints directly over historical materials, keeping the inherited account visible while interrupting its sequence, categories, and authority.



Faith Ringgold, *Tar Beach (Part I from the Woman on a Bridge series)*, 1988. Acrylic paint, canvas, printed, dyed, and pieced fabric. Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum, New York.

The Archive as Material



Firelei Báez, *Man Without a Country (aka anthropophagist wading in the Artibonite River)*, 2014–15. Gouache, ink, and chine collé on 225 deaccessioned book pages; installation view and cropped detail from the same supplied photograph. Exact venue and photographer are not established by the supplied photograph.

Where It Gets Complicated

Tradition is not neutral. Eliot's own version imagines a coherent European literary order. Many artists encounter the relevant past through fragments, unnamed makers, objects classified as craft or ritual, colonial collections, deaccessioned pages, family stories, damaged archives, or work that institutions failed to preserve. In that situation, lineage is not something the artist simply inherits. The artist may have to recover a relation that official history broke or construct one the archive never recognized.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 2.1 Who Arranged the Archive? · 2.2 Name the Operation · 2.3 Put the Works Beside Each Other

Exercise 2.1: Who Arranged the Archive?

Begin with one actual source you are using: a photograph, book, object, story, pattern, database, family record, museum label, found image, or inherited tool.

1. Where did you encounter it?
2. What category or description came attached to it?
3. Who named, preserved, circulated, or excluded it?
4. What remains missing or difficult to see?
5. What has that prior arrangement already made easy or difficult for your work?

The philosophical question: A source does not arrive outside history. The archive has already shaped the relation before the artist begins.

Exercise 2.2: Name the Operation

Choose one inherited form, image, process, text, material, or convention that is active in your work.

Circle one verb: **extend, interrupt, combine, rearrange, recover, refuse**.

Make one small test using that verb. Change a sequence, separate a source from its usual frame, place two materials together, remove an expected element, or restore a relation that has been difficult to see.

The philosophical question: Individual talent becomes visible in what the work does with inherited material, not in pretending the inheritance is absent.

Put the Works Beside Each Other

Exercise 2.3: Put the Works Beside Each Other

Place the test from Exercise 2.2 beside its source or an earlier work that belongs beside it. Write:

- The earlier work helps me see _____ in my test.
- My test makes _____ in the earlier work newly visible.
- The operation I can now name is _____.

Name one next material, formal, or spatial decision that would strengthen that operation.

The philosophical question: A lineage can explain a work, and the new work can reorganize the lineage.

Go Further with the Framework

Accessible Reading List

- T. S. Eliot. ***Tradition and the Individual Talent***
  Primary text on historical sense and reciprocal adjustment between new work and predecessors. · Free/open
- Langdon Hammer / Open Yale Courses. ***T. S. Eliot***
  A free lecture and transcript on Eliot's relationship to tradition, quotation, impersonality, and "Tradition and the Individual Talent." · Free/open
- Nasrullah Mambrol. ***Analysis of T. S. Eliot's Tradition and the Individual Talent***
  A section-by-section introduction to the historical sense, the existing order, and Eliot's impersonal theory of poetry. · Free/open
- Wikipedia. ***Tradition and the Individual Talent***
  A quick orientation to the essay's two parts, central terms, publication history, and critical reception. · Free/open

Further Reading

- Paul Stasi. ***The Future Holds More Than the Past Has Yielded: T. S. Eliot's Invention of Tradition and the St. Louis Exposition of 1904***
  A historical study of how Eliot's supposedly timeless tradition was made through a specific encounter with modernity, empire, and display. · Open-access PDF
- Kate Klonowski. ***'Tradition' and the Solitary Singer: Taking Exception to T. S. Eliot's Literary Legacy***
  Sets Whitman beside Eliot and shows how Whitman anticipates and reworks Eliot's retrospective theory of tradition. · Open-access PDF
- Aarthi Vadde. ***Theories of Anthologizing and Decolonization***
  Shows how anthologies actively build literary traditions, then asks what changes when canon-making is treated as a decolonial practice. · Open-access PDF
- Nathan Suhr-Sytsma. ***Postcolonial Poetry and the Decolonization of the English Literary Curriculum***
  Tests inherited literary order through postcolonial poetry and the institutional choices that decide which pasts remain available. · Open-access PDF

03 The Anxiety of Influence

Influence becomes productive through creative misreading. The later work makes room by taking the inherited form in another direction.

OVERVIEW

Harold Bloom published *The Anxiety of Influence: A Theory of Poetry* in 1973. He was writing specifically about poets; this toolkit extends his account to visual art because the studio problem is familiar across art forms. A powerful predecessor can occupy the imaginative space so completely that the important move feels as though it has already been made.

Bloom calls the later artist's productive response **misprision**, or creative misreading. This need not be a conscious strategy. The altered reading gives the new work somewhere to go.

One form of creative misreading is **clinamen**, the swerve. The later artist treats the precursor as if it moved in the right direction and then took a wrong turn. The new work makes the turn the precursor supposedly should have made.

The relation between Diego Velázquez's *Portrait of Pope Innocent X* and Francis Bacon's *Study after Velázquez's Portrait of Pope Innocent X* makes the mechanism visible. Bacon keeps the seated pope, the chair, the commanding scale, and the structure of institutional authority. He changes the direction of the image. The stable portrait becomes an image of a trapped, screaming body. The influence remains visible, but it behaves differently.

Amy Sillman gives us a broader case. In *Ghost*, the inherited language is not one painting but gestural abstraction and Abstract Expressionism. The brushstroke still carries the body, and scale still makes painting feel like an event. What changes is the authority of the mark. Edges reopen. Shapes are covered and revised. The painting keeps several possibilities active rather than presenting the gesture as a declaration of certainty.

In *After Metamorphoses*, influence becomes procedure. Sillman takes transformation from Ovid's *Metamorphoses* and moves it into an animation made through successive digital drawings. One drawing mutates into the next. The source may not remain visible as an image, but it becomes a rule for making.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Harold Bloom (1930–2019)

Bloom describes influence as a pressure exerted by powerful predecessors. Originality does not require freedom from influence. It emerges when the later artist creatively misreads the inheritance and makes a different formal or conceptual turn.

José Esteban Muñoz (1967–2013)

Muñoz describes disidentification as a strategy through which minoritarian subjects, especially queer people of color, work on and against dominant ideology. It is neither simple identification with dominant cultural codes nor total refusal. The artist can refunction a form while changing whom it serves, what body it imagines, or what the form is allowed to carry.

Amy Sillman (b. 1955)

Sillman works across painting, drawing, animation, and writing. Her work stays close to inherited painterly languages while using awkwardness, revision, instability, humor, and procedural change to resist their claims to authority.



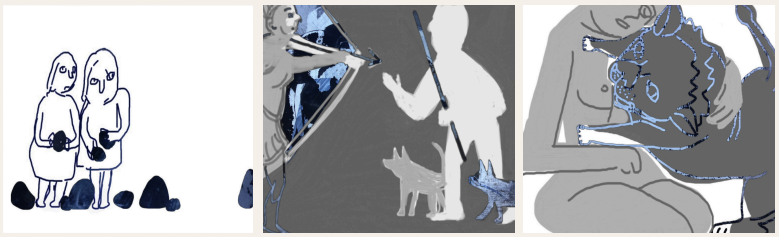


Diego Velázquez, *Portrait of Pope Innocent X*, c. 1650, oil on canvas, Galleria Doria Pamphilj, Rome; Francis Bacon, *Study after Velázquez's Portrait of Pope Innocent X*, 1953, oil on canvas, Des Moines Art Center. This pairing is the toolkit's Bloomian analogy, not Bloom's example.

Influence as Method



Amy Sillman, *Ghost*, 2023–24, acrylic and oil on linen. Courtesy of the artist.



Amy Sillman, *After Metamorphoses*, 2015–16. Video (animated drawing), color and sound; score by Wibke Tiarks. Selected stills.

Where It Gets Complicated

Bloom turns influence into a contest for priority between strong individual artists, often imagined as father and son. That can illuminate rivalry, but it cannot explain every artistic relation. Muñoz changes the stakes: from individual priority to power, survival, and minoritarian cultural production. Influence can also involve devotion, citation, affinity, community, study, pleasure, or chosen lineage. The formal question remains useful, but not every change is an attempt to defeat a predecessor.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 3.1 Keeps / Swerves · 3.2 Change One Variable · 3.3 Work On and Against

Exercise 3.1: Keeps / Swerves

Choose one active influence and one work of your own. Make two lists:

- **Keeps:** three things your work keeps from the influence, such as scale, structure, material, rhythm, palette, procedure, genre, or address.
- **Swerves:** one place where your work takes a different turn.

Keep the swerve close to a decision you can point to.

The philosophical question: Influence does not disappear when the work becomes yours. Originality can become visible in the change of direction.

Exercise 3.2: Change One Variable

Make two quick tests from the same influence.

1. Keep the influence visible.
2. In the first test, change one variable: scale, edge, material, rhythm, color, site, duration, or procedure.
3. In the second test, change a different variable.
4. Compare the two. Which change creates a real departure, and which only disguises the source?

The philosophical question: A swerve is not any difference. It is the changed decision that gives the later work somewhere to go.

Work On and Against

Exercise 3.3: Work On and Against

Choose an inherited form you do not want simply to accept or abandon.

Write:

- I want to stay inside this form because _____.
- I refuse its demand that _____.

Make one tactical change in address, body, material, role, audience, or use. Let the form remain recognizable while changing its terms.

Place the changed version beside the inherited form. Name what remains recognizable, what now operates differently, and whom the changed form can address, hold, or serve. Choose one of those differences to carry into the work.

The philosophical question: Disidentification makes room for an artist to inhabit an inherited form and alter what it can do.

Go Further with the Framework

Accessible Reading List

- Paul Fry / Open Yale Courses. ***Influence***
  Lecture and transcript on precursor, misprision, clinamen, and Bloom's revisionary ratios. · Free/open
- Wikipedia. ***Anxiety of Influence***
  A concise map of Bloom's argument, misprision, and the six revisionary ratios before entering the primary book. · Free/open
- The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica / Encyclopaedia Britannica. ***Harold Bloom***
  A specific overview of Bloom's career, major books, canon-making, and theory of literary influence. · Free/open
- Harold Bloom, interviewed by Antonio Weiss / The Paris Review. ***The Art of Criticism No. 1***
  A long-form interview that clarifies Bloom's critical practice and the role of influence in how he reads poets. · Free interview

Further Reading

- Eran Viezel. ***'The Anxiety of Influence': Rashbam's Approach to Rashi's Commentary on the Torah***
  A close scholarly application that tests Bloom's precursor model outside modern poetry through commentary, correction, and inherited authority. · Open-access PDF
- Jessica Hooten Wilson. ***Walker Percy, Fyodor Dostoevsky, and the Search for Influence***
  A book-length case study of imitation, borrowed critique, reversal, and remaking between a later novelist and a powerful predecessor. · Open-access PDF
- Piotr Sobolczyk. ***The Anxiety of Social Influence***
  Reworks Bloom's text-and-personality model through social psychology and queer literary contexts, redirecting the revisionary ratios toward social pressures on writers. · Open-access PDF
- Tõnis Parksepp. ***Aliens in Love: Testing Bloom's Theory of the Anxiety of Influence***
  Tests Bloom's universality by applying misreading to culturally distant prose texts and distinguishing rhetorical kinship from direct biographical influence. · Open-access PDF

04 Originality and Repetition

Claims of a fresh beginning often depend on forms, objects, and systems that can be repeated.

OVERVIEW

Rosalind Krauss published "The Originality of the Avant-Garde: A Postmodernist Repetition" in 1981. She takes aim at one of modernism's strongest stories: the artist or movement breaks with the past and arrives at a genuine beginning.

Krauss treats that beginning as a myth. A myth is not simply a lie. It is an organizing story that allows the work to appear self-originating even when the conditions that produced it are repeatable.

The modernist grid is one of her central examples. A grid can look like a ground zero: flat, abstract, and separate from the visible world. But its lines run to the edge as if the pattern could continue. The same structure can appear again in another work. The grid helps the painting look autonomous precisely because it is repeatable.

Bronze casting creates a different problem. Krauss points to a bronze of Rodin's *The Gates of Hell* made from his plaster after his death, under authority granted to the French state and Musée Rodin. Rodin neither made nor saw that bronze object, yet it can still be authenticated, exhibited, and collected as an original work. Its status depends on authorized relation, editioning, institutional convention, legal agreement, and art-historical judgment. We cannot discover that status simply by inspecting the object.

Krauss's point is not that individual artistic decisions disappear. Artists still determine color, scale, proportion, material, process, and context. Her point is that "original" cannot simply mean "made without repetition." Repetition often helps establish the conditions under which something can appear as original.

Sturtevant makes this problem impossible to ignore. Warhol's *Flowers* from 1964 and Sturtevant's *Warhol Flowers* from 1969–70 use the same image and silkscreen process; Sturtevant worked with a *Flowers* screen that Warhol provided to her. She does not hide the source or make the result visibly different enough to reassure the viewer. Warhol's name remains in her title.

The deliberate closeness is the operation. Appearance alone may not securely establish which artist made the work. The label, date, artist's name, exhibition history, and decision to repeat become part of the work. Visible transformation is not always where the contribution lies.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Rosalind Krauss (b. 1941)

Krauss is an art historian and critic whose 1981 essay connects modernist originality to repetition. Her examples show that supposedly new beginnings often depend on structures, series, casts, and conventions that can produce more than one work.

Sturtevant (Elaine Sturtevant, 1924–2014)

Sturtevant began remaking works by other contemporary artists in the 1960s, often while the source works were still new. Her repetitions do not conceal their sources. By staying deliberately close, they shift attention from visible difference to authorship, naming, recognition, memory, and institutional framing.





Left: Andy Warhol, *Flowers*, 1964. Silkscreen ink on linen. The Broad Art Foundation. **Right:** Sturtevant, *Warhol Flowers*, 1969–70. The exact medium is omitted because it was not established by the available object record.

Where It Gets Complicated

Repetition does not cancel originality, but repetition alone does not explain the artist's contribution. Saying that a work repeats an image, form, or process tells us where it begins, not what the artist does with it. The contribution may be a visible transformation in scale, material, sequence, or site. It may also be the deliberate decision to repeat closely enough that naming, date, context, and attribution become the problem of the work.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 4.1 Repetition Inventory · 4.2 Repeat Without Hiding the Source · 4.3 Move the Difference into the Frame

Exercise 4.1: Repetition Inventory

Choose one form, image, process, gesture, structure, or material you repeat in a current work.

Write:

- It comes from _____.
- It has appeared before in _____.
- Repeating it here lets me _____.

Keep the final sentence close to something the work actually does.

The philosophical question: Repeatability is not evidence that the work failed to be original. It is part of the condition the artist is working with.

Repeat Without Hiding the Source

Exercise 4.2: Repeat Without Hiding the Source

Choose one source and keep it recognizable.

Make one version that changes only one variable:

- scale
- material
- resolution
- tool or hand
- duration
- procedure
- support

Do not disguise the source. Ask which part of the contribution becomes visible through the controlled change.

The philosophical question: If the source remains legible, the work has to locate its contribution in the operation rather than in the appearance of novelty.

Move the Difference into the Frame

Exercise 4.3: Move the Difference into the Frame

Use the repeated version from Exercise 4.2. Keep its visible form unchanged and alter one contextual condition in a mock presentation:

- title or label
- sequence or neighboring work
- site or display height
- audience or route of access
- which accurate attribution, date, or edition information is foregrounded

Use mock labels or sketches for the comparison. Do not alter the work's factual provenance.

Present the two contexts side by side. What changes when the object or image does not? Write one sentence naming where the work's contribution now sits.

The philosophical question: Authorship and originality are not always visible properties of an object. Context, naming, sequence, and authorization can carry part of the work.

Go Further with the Framework

Accessible Reading List

- Tate. ***Appropriation***
  Introduction to using pre-existing images and objects while leaving the specific operation open to analysis. · Free/open
- Hito Steyerl / e-flux. ***In Defense of the Poor Image***
  Copies that compress, detach, accelerate, circulate, and acquire new audiences. · Free/open
- Walter Benjamin. ***The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction***
  How technical reproducibility changes authenticity, authority, exhibition, and reception. · Free MIT-hosted PDF
- Katherine Thomson-Jones and Shelby Moser / Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. ***The Philosophy of Digital Art***
  Originality and repeatability for files, software, perfect copying, variability, and display dependence. · Free/open

Further Reading

- Rex Butler. ***Rosalind Krauss: Between Modernism and Post-Medium***
  A sustained account of Krauss on medium, recursion, convention, and the paradox of a new form arising through reflection on prior forms. · Open university-repository PDF
- Peter Evan David Muir. ***Against the Will to Silence: An Intellectual History of the American Art Journal October between 1976 and 1981***
  Places Krauss, the Pictures exhibition, and October's critique of modernist autonomy inside their shared institutional and theoretical history. · Open university-repository PDF
- Keith Negus, John Street, and Adam Behr. ***Copying, Copyright and Originality: Imitation, Transformation and Popular Musicians***
  Distinguishes learning through imitation, transformative copying, and commercial copying rather than treating originality as a single yes-or-no property. · Open author-manuscript PDF
- Joost de Bloois. ***Introduction: The Artists Formerly Known As… Or, the Loose End of Conceptual Art and the Possibilities of 'Visual Autofiction'***
  Examines authorship after conceptual art, where citation, reenactment, fictive identity, and prior work become materials rather than threats to originality. · Open university-repository PDF

One Work, Four Questions

PRACTICE SYNTHESIS

Synthesis Worksheet · A Lineage Map

Choose one finished or in-progress work. Answer all four quickly, then circle the question that brings the work most clearly into focus.

Kant

What possibility does it open?

This can be modest. It may be a possibility inside your own practice.

Eliot

Which earlier work belongs beside it? What does the pairing make visible?

Choose one relation rather than trying to claim an entire lineage.

Bloom

Where does it take a different turn?

Name an influence and keep the answer close to one formal or procedural decision.

Krauss

What does repeating something let you do?

Name the repeated form, image, or process and the work it performs here.

I inherited or repeated… I changed…
The work now makes possible… The contribution I can name is…

The contribution I can name now is:

KEEP THE LANGUAGE CLOSE AT HAND

Glossary of Key Terms

Anxiety of Influence
Bloom's name for the pressure a later artist experiences when an earlier achievement seems to occupy the imaginative space.

Appropriation
The use of an existing image, object, style, or cultural material in a new work. The term alone does not settle whether the operation is citation, critique, homage, theft, extraction, or something else.

Archive
A collection and ordering of records, objects, images, or histories. An archive preserves material, but its categories also shape what becomes visible.

Avant-Garde
Artists and movements that define themselves through experiment, rupture, or a claim to begin again. Krauss examines how this claim depends on repetition.

Clinamen
The swerve: a creative misreading in which the later artist treats the precursor as having moved correctly and then taken a wrong turn.

Disidentification
Muñoz's term for how minoritarian subjects work on and against dominant ideology, neither simply identifying with dominant cultural codes nor refusing them altogether.

Exemplarity
Kant's term for the way an original work can become a model for others without becoming a recipe they can simply follow.

Genius
In Kant's aesthetics, the capacity through which fine art receives a rule that could not have been stated in advance.

Historical Sense
Eliot's term for the artist's awareness that the past is past and also active in the present work. It is acquired through study.

Individual Talent
In Eliot's essay, the transformation of inherited language, form, and experience that becomes visible in the new work.

Lineage
A relation among works, artists, materials, histories, communities, and practices across time. A lineage can be inherited, chosen, reconstructed, contested, or refused.

Misprision
Bloom's term for creative misreading: an altered reading of a precursor that gives the later work room to develop.

Originality
The condition of not being fully prescribed by an existing rule or model. Here, originality does not mean freedom from influence or creation from nothing.

Precursor
In Bloom's theory, the powerful earlier artist or work whose achievement exerts pressure on the later artist.

Recognition
The processes through which an artist or work becomes visible, legible, supported, remembered, and credited. Institutions and material conditions shape recognition as well as achievement.

Repetition
The return of a form, image, object, process, structure, or gesture. Repetition can be a condition, method, argument, or material of the work.

Tradition
For Eliot, an active order of earlier works that shapes the new work and is changed by the new work's arrival.